My Father's Hands

By Calvin R. Worthington

His hands were rough and exceedingly strong. He could gently prune a fruit-tree or firmly wrestle a stubborn mule into harness. He could draw and saw a square with quick accuracy. He had been known to peel his knuckles on a tough jaw. But what I remember most is the special warmth from those hands soaking through my shirt, as he would take me by the shoulder and, squatting beside my ear, point out the glittering swoop of a blue hawk, or a rabbit asleep in its lair. They were good hands that served him well and failed him in only one thing: they never learned to write.

INTRODUCTION

*In the early 1900s, supporting yourself and helping your family took priority over school if you were poor. And if you were poor and had a learning disability; school was simply not a necessity. Learning to read and write? Optional. Today these people are called functionally illiterate. And according to an article by Chloe Haderlie and Allysa Clark, in *2017 approximately 18% of American adults fell into this category.*

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My father was illiterate. The number of illiterates in the country has steadily declined, but if there were only one, I would be saddened, remembering my father and the pain he endured because his hands never learned to write.

When he started school, the remedy for a wrong answer was ten ruler strokes across a stretched palm. For some reason, shapes, figures and recitations just didn't fall into the right pattern inside his six-year-old tow-head. Maybe he suffered from some type of learning handicap such as dyslexia. His father took him out of school after several months and set him to a man's job on the farm.

Years later, his wife, educated to the fourth year of primary school, would try to teach him to read. And still later I would grasp his big fist between my small hands and awkwardly help him trace the letters of his name. He submitted to the ordeal, but soon grew restless. Flexing his fingers and kneading his palms, he would eventually declare that he had had enough and would depart for a long, solitary walk.

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Finally, one night when he thought no one saw, he slipped away with his son's second-grade reader and labored over the words, until they became too difficult. He pressed his forehead into the pages and wept. 'Jesus—Jesus—not even a child's book?' Thereafter, no amount of persuading could bring him to sit with pen and paper.

From the farm to road-building and later factory work, his hands served him well. His mind was keen, his will to work unsurpassed. During World War II, he was a pipefitter in a shipyard and installed the complicated guts of mighty fighting ships.

His enthusiasm and efficiency brought an offer to become a foreman — until he was handed the qualification test. His fingers could trace a path across the blueprints while his mind imagined the pipes lacing though the heard of the ship. He could recall every twist and turn of those pipes. But he couldn't read or write.

It has always been hard for him to stand before a man and make an X mark for his name, but the hardest moment of all was when he placed 'his mark' by the name someone

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else had written for him and saw another man walk away with the deed to his beloved farm. When it was over, he stood before the window and slowly turned the pen he still held in his hands—gazing, unseeing, down the mountainside. I went out to the barn that afternoon and wept for a long, long while.

Eventually, he found a cotton-mill job, and we moved into a millhouse village with a hundred look-alike houses. He never quite adjusted to town life. The blue of his eyes faded; the skin across his cheekbones became a little slack. But his hands kept their strength, and their warmth still soaked through when he would sit me on his lap and ask that I read to him from the Bible. He took great pride in my reading and would listen for hours as I struggled through awkward phrases.

Once he had heard 'a radio preacher' relate that the Bible said, 'The man that doesn't provide for his family is worse than a thief and an infidel and will never enter the Kingdom of Heaven.' Often he would ask me to read that part to him, but I was never able to find it. Other times, he would sit at the kitchen table leafing through the pages as though by a

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miracle he might be able to read the passage should he turn to the right page. Then he would sit staring at the Book, and I knew he was wondering if God was going to refuse him entry into heaven because his hands couldn't write.

When Mother left once for a weekend to visit her sister, Dad went to the store and returned with food for dinner. After the meal he said he had a surprise for dessert, and went out to the kitchen, where I could hear him opening a can. Then everything was quiet. I went to the doorway and saw him standing before the sink with an open can in his hand. 'The picture looked just like pears.' He mumbled. He walked out and sat on the back steps, and I knew he had been embarrassed. The can read 'Whole White Potatoes', but the illustration on the label did look a great deal like pears.

I went and sat beside him and asked if he would point out the stars. He knew where the Big Dipper and all the other stars were located, and we talked about how they got there in the first place. He kept that can on a shelf in the woodshed for a long while, and on several occasions I saw

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him turning it in his hands as if the touch of the words would teach his hands to write.

Years later, when Mom died, I tried to get him to come and live with my family, but he insisted on staying in his small weatherboard house on the edge of town with a few farm animals and a garden plot. His health was failing, and he was in and out of the hospital with several mild heart attacks. Old Doc Green saw him weekly and gave him medication, including nitroglycerin tablets to put under his tongue should he feel an attack coming on.

My last fond memory of Dad was watching as he walked across the brow of a hillside meadow, with those big, warm hands, now gnarled with age, resting on the shoulders of my two children. He stopped to point out them, confidentially, a pond where he and I had swum and fished years before. That night, my family and I flew to a new job and new home, overseas. Three weeks later, he was dead of a heart attack.

I returned alone for the funeral. Doc Green told me how sorry he was. In fact, he was bothered a bit, because he had

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just written Dad a new nitroglycerin prescription, and the chemist had made it up. Yet the bottle of pills had not been found on Dad's person. Doc Green felt that a pill might have kept him alive long enough to summon help.

An hour before the chapel service, I found myself standing near the edge of Dad's garden, where a neighbor had found him. In grief, I stopped to trace my fingers in the earth where a great man had reached the end of life. My hand came to rest on a half-buried brick, which I aimlessly lifted and tossed aside, before noticing underneath it the twisted and battered, yet unbroken, soft plastic bottle that had been beaten into the soft earth.

As I held the bottle of pills, the scene of Dad struggling to remove the cap and in desperation trying to break the bottle with the brick flashed painfully before my eyes. With anguish I knew why those big warm hands had lost in their struggle with death. For there, imprinted on the bottle cap, were the words, 'Child-Proof Cap—Push Down and Twist to Unlock'. The chemist later confirmed that he had just started using the new safety bottle.

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I knew it was not a purely rational act, but I went straight to town and bought a leather-bound pocket dictionary and a gold pen set. I bade Dad goodbye by placing them in those big old hands, once so warm, which had lived so well, but had never learned to write.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Calvin R. Worthington
Book: Reader's Digest; Volume 108, No 649, Pg 169
ISSN: 0034-0375
Publisher: Reader's Digest
Date (Month/Year): May 1976

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

****Source for statistics used in the introduction***

Haderlie, Chloe and Alyssa Clark. "Illiteracy Among Adults in the US." Ballard Brief. November 2017. https://ballardbrief.byu.edu/issue-briefs/illiteracy-among-adults-in-the-us